



K-12 SCHOOL RATINGS

SEARCHING & SAVING SCHOOLS

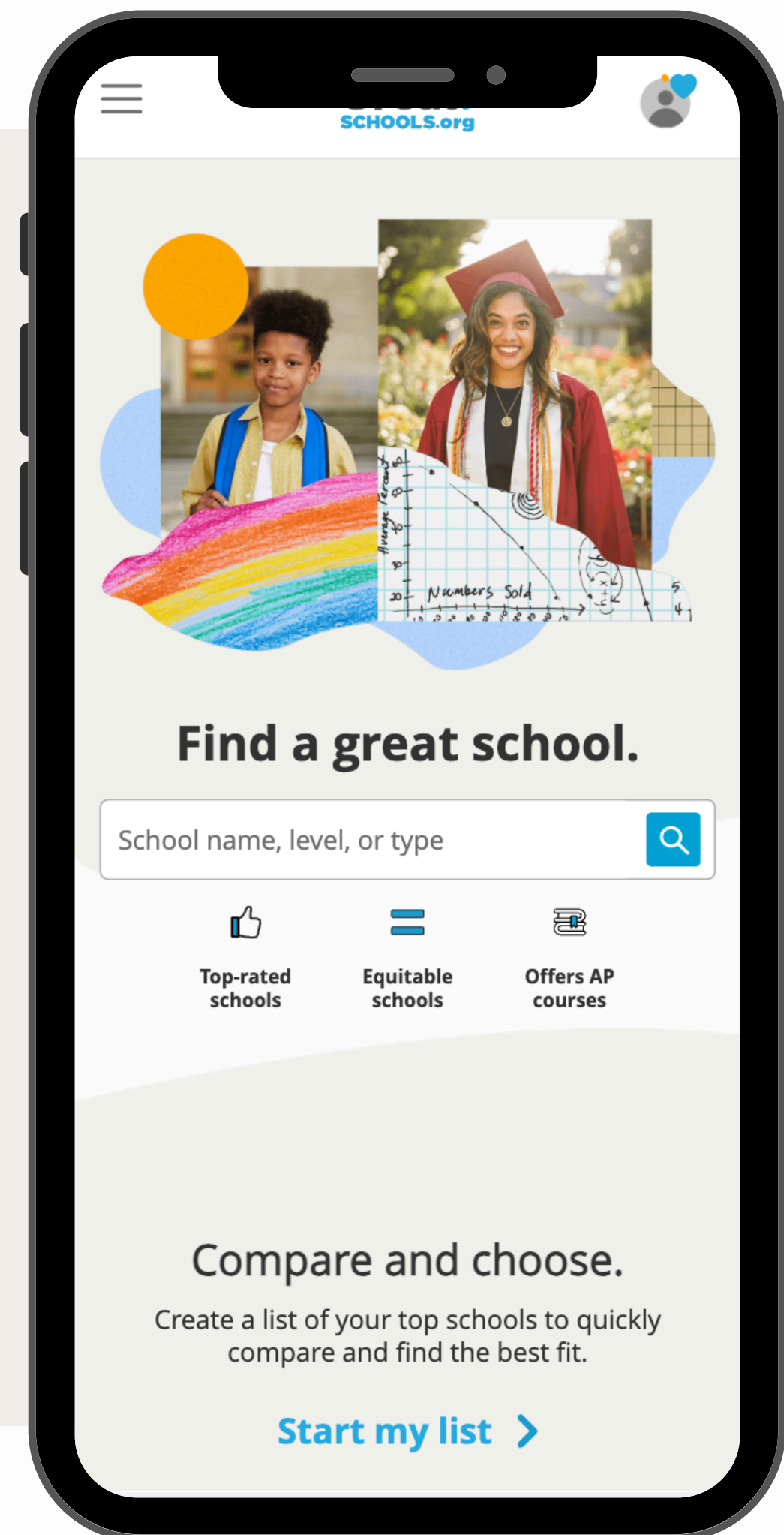
BUSINESS CONTEXT

- Non-profit organization founded in 1998 for California schools, went nationwide in 2003
- Provides information about PK-12 schools and education
 - Flagship product is a **database of schools in the US**
 - Aims to raise awareness of discrepancies
 - Enable schools to improve performance
 - Empower parents to pick schools
- Market has become more competitive in recent years
 - Began conducting more market and UX research

The logo for Great!SCHOOLS.org is displayed on a blue rectangular background. The word "Great!" is in a large, white, sans-serif font, with the exclamation mark being particularly prominent. Below it, the word "SCHOOLS.org" is in a smaller, white, sans-serif font, with "SCHOOLS" in all caps and ".org" in lowercase.

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- Most users are parents looking for a new K-12 school
- Previous research included
 - Information about when, why parents look for schools
 - Personas showing what parents are looking for
- UX Designer had not had the bandwidth to conduct additional research on our flagship product
- I joined as sole UX Researcher, and stakeholders asked:
 - How can we fulfill UXR requirements for a grant?
 - How can we make our product better?



DEFINING & PRIORITIZING

Collaborating with stakeholders

- Identified & met with key stakeholders
 - PM over the search experience, school list
 - Fundraising lead responsible for grant fulfillment
 - UX Designer
- Gathered information about what next steps were on the table vs. scoped out
- Identified key research questions and noted
 - Required research methods
 - Motivation/reasons for each question
 - Potential impact of answering the questions
 - Overlap between similar questions
 - Urgency for each question
- Proposed a research plan
- Checked-in async with secondary stakeholders and on Zoom with primary stakeholder

Uncertainty & other limitations

- Engineering
 - In the middle of transitioning from Google Analytics to MixPanel
- Scope
 - Uncertainty about preferred participants
- Stakeholders
 - 2 of 3 viewed themselves as the key stakeholder
 - None had ever worked with a UX Researcher
 - Resistance to qualitative methods
 - Many questions around collaboration
- Timing
 - Answer *some* questions within two weeks
 - Fast follow (part 2) would be acceptable

SYNTHESIZING TO CREATE

Research goals

- Can a new user complete key tasks?
 - Search for a school
 - Save a school to their list (and remove it)
- What do parents look for in a K-12 school?
 - What do they say?
 - What do they *do*?

Research plan

1. Unmoderated usability study
 - a. Assess usability of non-users' experiences
2. Moderated user interviews
 - a. Understand what users *say* they want
 - b. Create a journey map
3. Analysis of backend data
 - a. Determine what users actually *do*
4. Survey
 - a. Create a multiple-choice survey
 - b. Check potential gaps between the experiences of our users & non-users

QUALITATIVE FINDINGS

Insights

Unmoderated usability test (n=10)

-  All users were able to search for a school
-  A few users were able to create accounts
 - Discovered Facebook/Gmail bug on mobile
 - Discovered dropdown bug on desktop
-  Some users were unsure whether the school was successfully saved or not
-  Validated hypothesis that users' geography influences their experiences
-  Some users struggled to find their list
-  Users were delighted by ability to compare schools, but most did not discover this feature

Moderated interviews (n=10)

-  Journey map about the process
-  Insight into what info is perceived as
 - Essential vs. nice-to-have
 - Intuitive vs. confusing

Methods to create impact

- Inviting stakeholders to interviews
- Write-up with "TLDR" summary
- Read-out on Zoom
- Research repository
 - "Status" field for each insight

Impact

Engineering

-  Resolved login/signup bugs
-  Added text next to icon: "saved" and "save"

Research

-  Creation of self-service recruitment guide
-  A/B test and decision to change iconography
-  Shaped the follow-up survey

Data

-  Seek new information to add to profiles

Design

-  Clarify existing information, like ratings

QUANTITATIVE FINDINGS

Insights

Survey - with SurveyMonkey

- Most parents were looking for a school because their child was “aging out” (e.g., finishing 5th grade), but others were dissatisfied, moving, etc.
- Most parents reported their top concern was the academics of potential schools

Backend data - on MixPanel

- Many users click “save”, but the number of successful saves is far lower.
- The majority of clicks to access “my list” come from power users.

Impact

Survey

- 💡 This has influenced the content (e.g., blogs, podcasts, social media) we have made.
- 💡 This led to more questions, and the decision to do follow-up research about
 - Types of search queries
 - School profile
 - “Hero” portion
 - “Ratings” - especially the understandability
 - “Tie-breaker” attributes for similar schools

Backend data

- 💡 Ideating around streamlining the signup/login process
- 💡 Ideating potential solutions



QUESTIONS?



CREDITS

Title slide	Hayyan Creative Studio
Deck template	Saga Design Studio
Headshot	Framed By Two

A decorative graphic featuring a central light beige rounded rectangle. It is framed by orange lines: a horizontal line at the top, a horizontal line at the bottom, a vertical line on the left, and a vertical line on the right. The corners of the frame are rounded. In each of the four corners, outside the beige rectangle, there is a circle with diagonal stripes: top-left is pink, top-right is blue, bottom-left is pink, and bottom-right is blue. The background is white with a grid of black dots in the top-left and bottom-right corners.

APPENDIX

NEW USER FLOW

Great!SCHOOLS.org

Find a great school.

School name, level, or type

Top-rated schools

Equitable schools

Offers AP courses

Compare and choose.

Create a list of your top schools to quickly compare and find the best fit.

Start my list >

Great!SCHOOLS.org

roosevelt

Seattle, WA

SCHOOLS

Roosevelt High School

Seattle, WA

Roosevelt Elementary School

Tacoma, WA

Roosevelt Elementary School

Olympia, WA

Roosevelt Elementary School

Port Angeles, WA

Roosevelt Elementary School

Bellingham, WA

DISTRICTS

Roosevelt Elementary District

Phoenix, AZ

Roosevelt Union Free School District

Roosevelt, NY

Roosevelt Independent School District

Lubbock, TX

Theodore Roosevelt School

Great!SCHOOLS.org

Washington > Seattle > Seattle Public Schools

Roosevelt High School

Unclaimed

7/10

GreatSchools Rating

14 reviews

COLLEGE SUCCESS

Public school • 1,541 Students • Grades 9-12 • [Contact](#) • [Address](#)

Save

Updates

Review

Overview

Roosevelt High School is a public school in [Seattle, WA](#), offering AP courses, 2 sports, and Project Lead The Way curriculum. It is one of 25 high schools in [Seattle Public Schools](#).

School Rating

Roosevelt High School is performing **above average** compared to public and charter schools in Washington with the same grade levels.

Great!SCHOOLS.org

Notes

Why did you save this school?

GreatSchools Rating

Location

School Type

Reviews

Demographics

Location

Teachers & Staff

Courses & Programs

Add status

Scheduled Tour

Add a note...

0 / 280

Cancel

Save

Great!SCHOOLS.org

Washington > Seattle > Seattle Public Schools

Roosevelt High School

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Your saved schools in

Washington

Sort by: GreatSchools Rating

Cascadia Elementary

9/10

GreatSchools Rating

9

Student Progress

10

Equity

1700 N 90th Street, Seattle, WA, 98115 • ★ 5 (3 Reviews)

Elementary school

Public district

Add note



Homes nearby

Roosevelt High School

7/10

GreatSchools Rating

9

Test Scores

4

Equity

1410 Northeast 66th Street, Seattle, WA, 98115 •

★ 3.1 (14 Reviews)

High school

Public district

View note

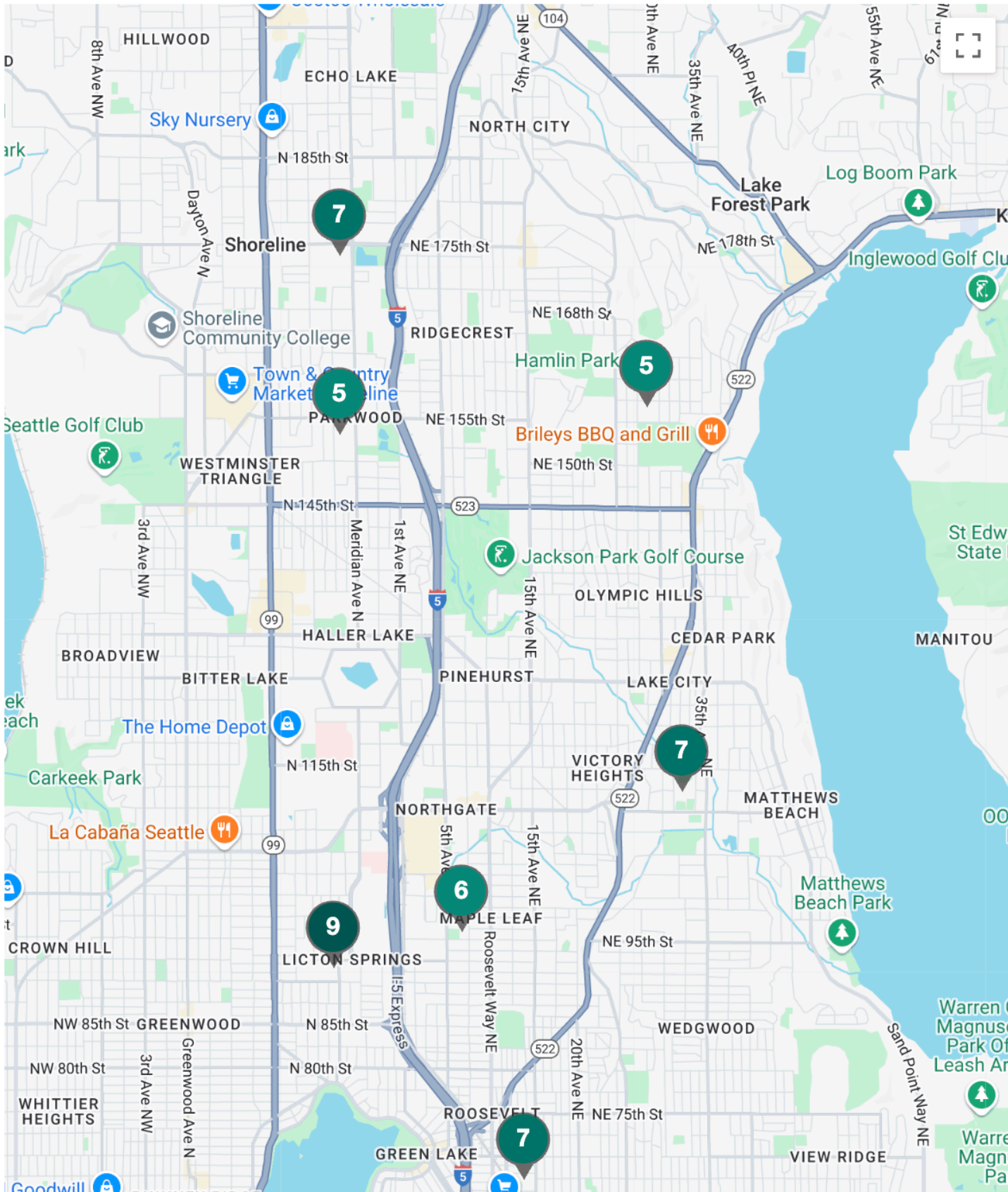


Homes nearby

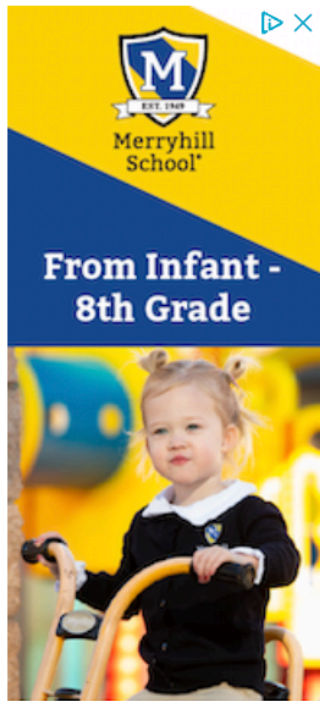
Meridian Park Elementary School

7/10

GreatSchools Rating



About GreatSchools Ratings



Make the Most
of Your
Child's Potential
at
Merryhill School

Now Accepting
Applications for the
2025-26
School Year

Advertisement



Your saved schools in



Washington ▾

[About GreatSchools Ratings](#)

Overview

[Ratings Snapshot](#)

[Equity: Test scores](#)

School	Type	Grades	Total students enrolled	Students per teacher	Reviews	District
9/10 Above average Cascadia Elementary 1700 N 90th Street, Seattle, WA, 98115 Homes nearby	Public district	K-5	474	19:1	3 Reviews ★ 5	Seattle Public Schools
7/10 Above average Roosevelt High School 3 awards 1410 Northeast 66th Street, Seattle, WA, 98115 Homes nearby	Public district	9-12	1541	22:1	14 Reviews ★ 3.1	Seattle Public Schools
7/10 Above average Meridian Park Elementary School 17077 Meridian Avenue North, Shoreline, WA, 98133 Homes nearby	Public district	K-5	527	16:1	5 Reviews ★ 4	Shoreline School District
7/10 Above average Jane Addams Middle School 11051 34th Avenue Northeast, Seattle, WA, 98125 Homes nearby	Public district	6-8	883	18:1	19 Reviews ★ 3.5	Seattle Public Schools
6/10 Average Olympic View Elementary School 504 Northeast 95th Street, Seattle, WA, 98115 Homes nearby	Public district	K-5	361	16:1	5 Reviews ★ 5	Seattle Public Schools
5/10 Average Briarcrest Elementary School					10 Reviews	Shoreline School

Customer Journey Map

